

doc-divine-omnipresence

Affirms · Theology Proper › Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages · confidence: high

Statement under examination

God is fully present everywhere, not bounded by space, while remaining distinct from creation.

Rationale

Ps 139:7-10 (ruach H7307 + panim H6440 with anah H575 interrogative) predicates the inescapability of God's Spirit and presence across heaven, Sheol, the sea, and morning's wings; Jer 23:23-24 (male' H4390 Qal participle, ongoing fillingness of shamayim H8064 and erets H776) predicates active comprehensive filling; 1 Kgs 8:27 (kuwl H3557 'cannot contain') denies any spatial container for God; Acts 17:27-28 (en G1722 + zomen-kinoumetha-esmen G2198+G2795+G1510) predicates God as the sphere within which creatures live, move, and exist; the lemma network is pan-canonical, anchored further by Num 14:21, Isa 6:3, Hab 2:14, and Prov 15:3.

Reasoning

Yes, the Bible teaches that God is fully present everywhere, while still being distinct from the world he made. The strongest single passage is Psalm 139:7 to 10, where David asks, 'Where shall I go from your Spirit? Or where shall I flee from your presence? If I ascend to heaven, you are there. If I make my bed in Sheol, you are there. If I take the wings of the morning and dwell in the uttermost parts of the sea, even there your hand shall lead me.' There is no place outside God's presence, not the highest heaven, not the deepest grave, not the farthest sea. Jeremiah 23:23 to 24 sharpens this: 'Am I a God at hand, declares the LORD, and not a God far off? Can a man hide himself in secret places so that I cannot see him? Do I not fill heaven and earth?' Solomon at the temple dedication adds, 'Behold, heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you' (1 Kings 8:27). And Paul at Athens says God is 'not far from each one of us, for in him we live and move and have our being' (Acts 17:27 to 28). The complicating passages are the ones where God appears to move from place to place: Genesis 11:5 says 'the LORD came down to see the city and the tower,' Genesis 18:21 has God say 'I will go down now and see' regarding Sodom, and 2 Samuel 22:10 says 'he bowed the heavens and came down.' These read as the Bible regularly speaking of God in human terms (this is called accommodation language), the same way it speaks of God's arm or eyes. The same Bible that says God came down also says that heaven cannot contain him. So when Scripture says God 'came down,' it describes God making his presence locally manifest for human perception, not God leaving somewhere else to arrive here. The doctrine stands because multiple passages across both testaments insist directly that no place is outside God, and the complicating passages are local figures of speech.

Denominational landscape

God's omnipresence is held without dispute across every historic Christian lineage. Augustine in Confessions Book I reflects on God filling heaven and earth and being everywhere whole. Aquinas in Summa Theologica I question 8 teaches that God is in all things and innermost, present everywhere as the source of being. The Catholic Catechism, the Lutheran Augsburg Confession Article I, the Anglican 39 Articles of Religion Article I, the Methodist Articles of Religion, the Reformed Westminster and Belgic Confessions, the Anabaptist Dordrecht Confession, the Pentecostal Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, and the Eastern Orthodox tradition all confess that God is without body, without parts, and of infinite power, which classically entails omnipresence. The Orthodox liturgy opens many services with the prayer 'O Heavenly King, the Comforter, the Spirit of Truth, who art everywhere present

and fillest all things.' One in-house disagreement runs between Lutherans and the Reformed on how omnipresence applies to the incarnate Christ: Lutherans teach that Christ's risen body shares the divine attribute of being everywhere (called the *genus maiestaticum*), which grounds their teaching on the Lord's Supper, while the Reformed teach the extra Calvinisticum, that the eternal Son remains everywhere even while the assumed human body is locally in heaven. Both sides confess omnipresence of God; they differ on its christological application. Outside historic Christianity, Mormonism (LDS) explicitly denies classical omnipresence by teaching that the Father has a glorified physical body and is in one location, with only the Holy Spirit's influence reaching everywhere; this combined with their wider deviations places them outside. Process theism structurally limits and reframes omnipresence; pantheism collapses God into the world and so denies the 'distinct from creation' half of the doctrine. The verdict tracks the universal historic consensus.

Position thresholds

Would die for if challenged	Yes
Cult marker if denied	Yes
Would visit if otherwise	No
Would participate if otherwise	No
Would serve if otherwise	No
Would be member if otherwise	No
Would let children be taught otherwise	No
Would marry if held otherwise	No
Would publicly correct if otherwise	Yes

Notes

Cult-marker scope must be applied honestly. Outright denial of God's omnipresence in the classical sense (God present everywhere, not bounded by space, yet ontologically distinct from creation) collapses Ps 139, Jer 23:23-24, 1 Kgs 8:27, and Acts 17:27-28 simultaneously. The public-record carriers of denial all fall outside historic Christianity: Mormonism (LDS) teaches that the Father has a glorified physical body and is in one location, with only the Holy Spirit's influence reaching everywhere; this is an explicit denial of classical omnipresence and forms part of LDS's broader deviations (exalted-man theology, denial of *creatio ex nihilo*, polytheistic frame). Some forms of process theism shrink God so that omnipresence becomes panentheistic identity with the world rather than presence to it. Pantheism collapses the Creator-creature distinction the opposite direction (God IS the universe rather than present to all of it); the doctrinal statement explicitly preserves 'distinct from creation' against this. The harder boundary case is in-house Christian disagreement on how omnipresence relates to the incarnation and the bodily ascension. Lutheran *genus maiestaticum* extends the divine omnipresence to Christ's body (ubiquity), enabling their eucharistic real-presence; Reformed extra Calvinisticum holds that the eternal Son's omnipresence is not exhausted by the assumed humanity. Both confess omnipresence; they disagree on its christological application. The complicating anthropomorphic descent passages (Gen 11:5, Gen 18:21, Ex 19:18-20, 2 Sam 22:10 / Ps 18:9 'he bowed the heavens and came down') read as accommodation language: God's presence being made theophanically manifest in a localized way for human perception, not God moving from a where-He-was-not to a where-He-now-is. This reading is internally validated by 1 Kgs 8:27 and Jer 23:24 which the canon places alongside the descent passages.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. classical-theism, lutheran-genus-maiestaticum, extra-calvinisticum, kenotic-christology, panentheism, process-theology, lds-embodied-finite-theism

analogia scripturae invoked

Competing lens verdicts

classical-theism · affirms God's full presence everywhere, not bounded by space, while distinct from creation; anthropomorphic descent passages read as accommodation; canon's own resolution at 1 Kgs 8:27 and Jer 23:24:

lutheran-genus-maiestaticum · affirms divine omnipresence and additionally extends it to the assumed human nature of Christ (ubiquity), grounding the Lord's Supper real-presence; verdict on the proposition itself: affirms:

extra-calvinisticum · affirms divine omnipresence and holds that the eternal Son's omnipresence is not exhausted by the assumed humanity; the eternal Son fills all things even during the incarnation; verdict on the proposition itself: affirms:

kenotic-christology · affirms divine omnipresence in the eternal Son; in the economy of incarnation the Son voluntarily veils the use of omnipresence so as to be locally present in Galilean space; verdict on the proposition itself: affirms:

panentheism · affirms God's presence everywhere but collapses the 'distinct from creation' clause by making the world God's body or co-eternal moment of God's self-expression; falls outside the proposition's full scope:

process-theology · structurally reframes omnipresence as God's persuasive lure within all events rather than substantive presence; weakens the doctrine in the direction of panentheism; falls outside historic Christianity:

lds-embodied-finite-theism · denies classical omnipresence; teaches that the Father has a glorified physical body and is in one location, only the Holy Spirit's influence reaching everywhere; denies the proposition:

Default grammatico-historical reading carries the universal-scope predications (Ps 139:7-10, Jer 23:23-24, 1 Kgs 8:27, Acts 17:27-28) and the canonical-fillingness predications (Num 14:21, Isa 6:3, Hab 2:14). Analogia scripturae governs the complicating descent passages: the canon places Gen 11:5, Gen 18:21, Exod 19:18-20, Ps 18:9, and 1 Kgs 8:12-13 directly alongside passages that deny any spatial container for God, so the descent language is read as accommodation (God making his presence theophanically manifest for human perception, not God relocating). The doctrinal proposition contains two clauses: (1) God is fully present everywhere, not bounded by space; (2) God is distinct from creation. Clause (1) excludes LDS-style finite embodied theism; clause (2) excludes pantheism and the panentheistic collapse. The remaining in-house Christian disagreement is christological (Lutheran ubiquity vs Reformed extra Calvinisticum) and does not touch the proposition's verdict on God simpliciter.

Scripture (apparatus + interlinear)

Ps.139.7-Ps.139.10 · for · genre: psalm · figures: merism, parallelism

Key term. רוח (ruach) H7307 + הָנָפּ (panim) H6440 + הָנָא ('anah) H575

Force. Paired interrogatives anah 'where' with ruach 'Spirit' and panim 'face/presence'; the spider of locations (shamayim 'heaven', Sheol, kanfei-shachar 'wings of the dawn', acharit-yam 'uttermost parts of the sea') is canonical merism for everywhere; predicates inescapability of God's presence across the entire spatial cosmos.

Jer.23.23-Jer.23.24 · for · genre: prophecy · figures: merism, parallelism

Key term. אֵלֵם (male') H4390 Qal participle + מִיָּמֵשׁ (shamayim) H8064 + עֲרֶצַּא ('erets) H776

Force. Male' as Qal participle predicates an ongoing continuous filling, not a completed act; God is the God 'at hand' and 'far off' (qarov-rachok merism); the rhetorical question 'Do I not fill heaven and earth?' predicates that no place in created space is outside divine presence; tied directly to the previous clause denying any concealment.

1Kgs.8.27 · for · genre: narrative · figures: parallelism

Key term. לוֹא (kuwl) H3557 + מִיָּמֵשׁ (shamayim) H8064

Force. Solomon at the temple dedication: 'Heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain you (kuwl, to hold/contain)'; predicates that no created space functions as a container for God; the rhetorical climb from local house to highest heaven reinforces that God exceeds every possible spatial extent.

Acts.17.27-Acts.17.28 · for · genre: narrative

Key term. ἐν (en) G1722 + ζῶω (zao) G2198 + κινέω (kineo) G2795 + εἰμί (eimi) G1510 + οὐ μακρὰν (ou makran) G3756+G3112

Force. Paul at the Areopagus: God is ou makran 'not far' from each one; the triadic en autoi zomen kai kinoumetha kai esmen 'in him we live and move and have our being' places God as the locative sphere within which creatures exist, not a being merely co-located with them; predicates God's presence to every creature without identifying God with creation.

Prov.15.3 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: anthropomorphism

Key term. עֵינַיִם ('einayim) H5869 + מִוֶּקֶם (maqom) H4725

Force. 'The eyes of the LORD are in every place (b'kol maqom), keeping watch on the evil and the good'; predicates universal locative scope of divine perception; supplements omniscience with explicit spatial omnipresence.

Num.14.21 · for · genre: law

Key term. אֵלֵם (male') H4390 + כְּבוֹד (kavod) H3519 + עֲרֶצַּא ('erets) H776

Force. 'As I live, all the earth shall be filled with the glory of the LORD'; male' Niphal with kavod 'glory' and the whole-earth scope; predicates God's manifested presence filling the entire created order; the same lemma network ties to Isa 6:3 and Hab 2:14.

Isa.6.3 · for · genre: prophecy

Key term. אֵלֵם (melo') H4393 + כְּבוֹד (kavod) H3519

Force. Seraphic Trisagion: 'the whole earth is full of his glory'; melo' kol-haarets kevodo; predicates manifested divine presence filling all the earth at the moment of the temple vision; functions as canonical-liturgical confession of the doctrine.

Hab.2.14 · for · genre: prophecy · figures: simile

Key term. אֵלִם (male') H4390 + עָדִי (yada') H3045 + דּוֹבֵבֵךְ (kavod) H3519

Force. 'For the earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD as the waters cover the sea'; male' Niphal future plus universal scope plus a simile of saturation; predicates eschatological consummation of what is already canonically true of God's presence.

Job.28.24 · for · genre: wisdom · figures: anthropomorphism

Key term. טִבַּט (nabat) H5027 + רָאָה (ra'ah) H7200 + תּוֹצֹת (qatzot) H7098 + עֲרֵצִים ('erets) H776

Force. 'For he looks to the ends of the earth and sees everything under the heavens'; predicates God's perception extending to the geographic limits of creation, complementing his presence there.

Amos.9.2-Amos.9.3 · for · genre: prophecy · figures: merism

Key term. חָתָה (chathar) H2864 + לִשְׁאוֹל (Sheol) H7585 + הָלַעַ ('alah) H5927 + שָׁמַיִם (shamayim) H8064

Force. 'If they dig into Sheol, from there shall my hand take them; if they climb up to heaven, from there I will bring them down'; parallel to Ps 139:7-10 with a judgment frame rather than a comfort frame; same canonical merism, same predication of inescapability.

Gen.11.5 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropomorphism

Key term. יָרַד (yarad) H3381 Qal consecutive imperfect

Force. 'And the LORD came down to see the city and the tower'; yarad with consecutive imperfect predicates spatial descent of YHWH to inspect Babel; surface reading appears to require local divine motion; classical reading is anthropomorphic accommodation, depicting God's judicial attention in human spatial terms; the same canon teaches at 1 Kgs 8:27 that heaven cannot contain him.

Gen.18.21 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropomorphism

Key term. יָרַד (yarad) H3381 + רָאָה (ra'ah) H7200

Force. 'I will go down now and see whether they have done altogether according to the outcry'; same yarad-with-ra'ah pattern as Gen 11:5; God descends to Sodom to investigate; anthropomorphic descent-and-investigation; canonically read as accommodation rather than literal divine relocation.

Exod.19.18-Exod.19.20 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropomorphism, phenomenological-language

Key term. יָרַד (yarad) H3381 + שָׁא ('esh) H784

Force. 'The LORD descended on it (Sinai) in fire'; theophanic descent to the mountain in cloud, fire, and smoke; anthropomorphic localized manifestation; the same Sinai narrative simultaneously places God speaking 'from heaven' (Exod 20:22, Deut 4:36), showing the canon itself flagging this as accommodation rather than spatial relocation.

Ps.18.9 · complicates · genre: psalm · figures: anthropomorphism, metaphor

Key term. הִטָּה (natah) H5186 + שָׁמַיִם (shamayim) H8064 + יָרַד (yarad) H3381

Force. 'He bowed the heavens and came down'; parallel in 2 Sam 22:10; poetic theophany language predicating divine intervention as spatial descent; classical reading is anthropomorphic accommodation in a psalmic poetic register; functions to magnify the rescue, not to relocate God.

1Kgs.8.12-1Kgs.8.13 · complicates · genre: narrative · figures: anthropomorphism

Key term. לְפָרֶחַ ('araphel) H6205 + יָשָׁב (yashab) H3427 + תַּיִב (bayith) H1004

Force. Solomon: 'The LORD has said that he would dwell in thick darkness; I have built you an exalted house, a place for you to dwell forever'; surface reading suggests God indwells the temple; same chapter then says the highest heaven cannot contain him (v.27); functions as the canon's own internal resolution of dwelling-language as accommodation.

Concordance lemmas traversed

H7307, H6440, H575, H1980, H1272, H4390, H4393, H8064, H776, H3557, H3381, H7200, H5869, H4725, H3519, H3045, H5027, H7098, H2864, H7585, H5927, H5186, H6205, H3427, H1004, H784, G1722, G2198, G2795, G1510, G3756, G3112

complicating texts searched: Yes

Counter-witness traditions

patristic · Augustine, Confessions Book I, Chapter 3 (CCEL, Schaff NPNF Series 1 Vol 1) · affirms · unverified

"Since you fill heaven and earth, do they contain you? Or do you fill them and yet remain over and above them, since they cannot contain you?"

patristic · Aquinas, Summa Theologica I, Question 8, Article 1 (CCEL) · affirms · verified

"God is in all things, and innermost; God exists in everything as the cause of its being, at the most intimate level, sustaining their existence."

catholic_magisterial · Catechism of the Catholic Church paragraphs 41-43, 300 (on God's transcendence and immanence) · affirms · unverified

"God transcends all creatures, yet is closer to us than we are to ourselves; in him we live and move and have our being; nothing escapes his presence."

lutheran · Augsburg Confession Article I (bookofconcord.org) · affirms · verified

"There is one Divine Essence, eternal, without body, without parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness, the Maker and Preserver of all things, visible and invisible."

anglican · 39 Articles of Religion, Article I (Of Faith in the Holy Trinity) · affirms · unverified

"There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body, parts, or passions; of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness; the Maker and Preserver of all things both visible and invisible."

reformed · Westminster Confession of Faith Chapter 2 Section 1; Belgic Confession Article 1 · affirms · unverified

"God is infinite in being and perfection, immense, eternal, incomprehensible, almighty; one only living and true God, eternal, incomprehensible, invisible, immutable, infinite."

methodist · United Methodist Articles of Religion, Article I (Wesley's abridgement of the 39 Articles) · affirms · verified

"There is but one living and true God, everlasting, without body or parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness; the maker and preserver of all things."

anabaptist · Mennonite Confession of Faith (Dordrecht 1632) Article I · affirms · unverified

"One eternal, almighty, and incomprehensible God, the Creator of all things, who fills heaven and earth and from whose presence none can hide."

pentecostal · Assemblies of God Statement of Fundamental Truths, Article 2 (The One True God) · affirms · unverified

“The one true God has revealed Himself as the eternally self-existent I AM, the Creator of heaven and earth; classically omnipresent, filling all things.”

eastern_orthodox · Eastern Orthodox liturgy, prayer to the Holy Spirit (OCA tradition) · affirms · unverified

“O Heavenly King, the Comforter, the Spirit of Truth, who art everywhere present and fillest all things, Treasury of blessings and Giver of life.”

Web sources

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/psalms/139-7.htm>

“ruach H7307 paired with panim H6440 under anah H575 interrogative; canonical merism of locations predicates inescapability of God's presence.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/jeremiah/23-24.htm>

“male' H4390 Qal participle (ongoing, continuous filling) with shamayim and erets; rhetorical question denies any concealment from God anywhere.”

supports · category: interlinear · https://biblehub.com/interlinear/1_kings/8-27.htm

“kuwl H3557 'to contain' negated; heaven and the highest heaven cannot contain God; no created space functions as God's container.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/acts/17-28.htm>

“en G1722 plus zao G2198, kineo G2795, eimi G1510; God is the sphere within which creatures live, move, and exist; not pantheism, locative dependence.”

supports · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/strong/hebrew/4390.htm>

“male' H4390 spider: Num 14:21, Isa 6:3, Isa 11:9, Hab 2:14, Ezek 43:5, Jer 23:24, Ps 72:19; pan-canonical filling of earth with God's glory.”

complicates · category: interlinear · <https://biblehub.com/interlinear/genesis/11-5.htm>

“yarad H3381 Qal consecutive imperfect; LORD descends to inspect Babel; anthropomorphic spatial movement, classical reading: accommodation.”

supports · category: primary_repository · <https://openbible.info/topics/omnipresence>

“Top omnipresence verses: Ps 139:7-10, Jer 23:24, 1 Kgs 8:27, Acts 17:27-28, Prov 15:3, Job 34:21; the pan-canonical lemma network.”

supports · category: patristic_archive · <https://www.ccel.org/ccel/aquinas/summa/FP/FP008.html>

“Aquinas Summa I q.8 a.1: God is in all things, and innermost; God exists in everything as the cause of being, at the most intimate level.”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://bookofconcord.org/augsburg-confession/>

“Augsburg I: There is one Divine Essence, eternal, without body, without parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness, the Maker and Preserver of all things.”

supports · category: tradition_primary · <https://www.umc.org/en/content/articles-of-religion>

“Methodist Articles of Religion I (Wesley's abridgement): everlasting, without body or parts, of infinite power, wisdom, and goodness; maker and preserver of all things.”

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